



Signs to notice and when to act

To help families notice a change from the person's usual self and act promptly.

Look for a change from usual

Relatives and close friends often notice first that something is different. Think about how the person normally talks, pays attention, moves, sleeps and manages everyday tasks.

Changes in thinking or attention

- Losing the thread of a conversation or being easily distracted
- Slow, muddled or unclear answers
- Not knowing where they are or what is happening
- New difficulty remembering recent events

Changes in alertness, behaviour or perception

- New sleepiness, withdrawal, reduced movement or poor response
- New restlessness, agitation, fear or suspiciousness
- Seeing or hearing things that others do not
- A changed sleep pattern or symptoms that come and go

What to do while help is coming

- Stay with the person if it is safe to do so.
- Say who you are and where they are. Reassure them in a calm voice.
- Use short, simple sentences. Avoid repeated questions or arguing.
- Gather an up-to-date medicines list and note when the change began.

Urgent action In the UK, call 999 or go to A&E now for new, sudden confusion. Do not drive yourself to A&E. Tell hospital or care-home staff immediately if the person is already in their care. Outside the UK, call your local emergency number or use your local emergency service.

Verified sources

- [NHS: Sudden confusion \(delirium\)](#)
- [NHS inform: Signs and symptoms of delirium](#)
- [NICE CG103: Indicators of delirium](#)
- [SIGN 157: Risk reduction and management of delirium](#)

Use and review: UK-focused general education. This resource supports but does not replace clinical assessment, individual advice or current local guidance. Prepared from source materials curated by Professor Alasdair MacLulich, University of Edinburgh; AI-assisted production. Professor MacLulich led development of the 4AT and reports no financial interest in its uptake. Final named human clinical approval is required before use in patient care. Independent resource; not an official University of Edinburgh or NHS publication.